

Federal jubilation

On July 4, 1863, Union troops marched into the city. One soldier wrote, "This was the most glorious Fourth I ever spent." Despite the feelings of pride in their hearts, Grant's victors displayed compassion and restraint to their erstwhile foes, sharing provisions with starving soldiers and civilians alike. One woman, watching the victorious Union troops, observed these "stalwart, well-fed men" and contrasted them with the city's emaciated former defenders, who had been "blindly dashed" against them.

Confederate loss, Union gain

In Richmond, Jefferson Davis blamed the loss on Pemberton, and to a slightly lesser extent, Johnston. In Washington, a grateful Abraham Lincoln waxed, "The Father of Waters [the Mississippi] again goes unvexed to the sea."

The fall of Vicksburg split the Confederacy irrevocably into two and ensured that cattle, metals, and grains from the Trans-Mississippi region would rarely again find their way to the Rebel states east of the river. Grant captured precious heavy cannon that the Confederacy could no longer replace, and the surrender of almost 30,000 men was a heavy blow to a South running out of manpower. Most significantly, the Union forces could now concentrate their efforts, and their growing numerical strength, against the remaining Confederate strongholds farther east.